

# YAHYAKHAN TAKES OVER POWER



# YAHYA SWORN IN

- Following the mass uprising on 29 March 1969 leading to the stepdown of Ayub Khan, Yahya Khan was sworn in as Chief Martial Law Administrator. In his first speech, he committed himself to the transfer of power to the elected representative.
- He began a round of consultation with the political parties. Bangabandhu Sheikh Mujibur Rahman proposed a Constituent Assembly to be elected on the basis of population.
- General Yahya Khan proceeded to hold countries “first and last” general election on 7<sup>th</sup> December 1970.
- To accommodate the various demands of the political parties, he proclaimed a Legal Framework Order (LFO) on 30 March 1970.



# LEGAL FRAMEWORK ORDER (LFO)

- Several bold measures were undertaken by this proclamation, which include among others:
  - a) in place of Presidential System there would be Parliament form of Govt
  - b) abolition of Basic Democracies which would be replaced by “one man one vote” system or Universal Adult Franchise
  - c) distribution of seats between the two wings according to numbers of population,
  - d) revival of four provinces in western wing by dismantling one unit system of West Pakistan
- But a derogatory power was retained in the hand of President which was to abolish the constituent assembly in case it failed to frame a constitution within 120 days.



# AWAMI LEAGUE DECIDES TO PARTICIPATE IN THE ELECTION

- Apart from the extraordinary power vested in the hands of President, the LFO conceded most of the demands of the Bengalis since the adoption of the six point programme.
- Against this backdrop, Awami League under the leadership of Bangabandhu Sheikh Mujibur Rahman took the historic decision to participate in the election of 1970.
- On 13 November, a massive cyclone swept through the coastal areas of Bangladesh, resulting in massive loss of life, live stock and other properties. Inaction by Yahya Khan and central govtin response to the cyclone was reported in both national and foreign media. This deeply touched the minds of the Bengalis. During this time, Awami League carried out massive relief and rehabilitation works in the affected area.





## Situation in Chalna Port takes serious turn

DACCA, Nov 12: A 75 miles rest of the districts fishing boats per hour cyclonic storm hit and trawlers in the north Bengal parts of Khulna district tonight. of Bengal were also asked according to an official report, stay in safety.

The affected places included Sarankhola, Royanda and Mangla under Bagerhat sub-division and Shamnagar P.S. under Satkhira sub-division. The areas form the forest belt in the district.

According to an earlier report, situation in Chelina Port was taking a serious turn. The low-lying areas are already under water.—APP.

The severe cyclonic storm after hitting the Khulna district is now apparently moving towards Chittagong coast. It may cross Chittagong and Cox's Bazar any time tonight according to a report received here.

The report said that the cyclone is raging at a speed of 80 miles per hour over Chaumohani and 40-50 mph over Sandwip and Hatya. A forecast by Patenga Met Office said under the influence of cyclonic weather Obhitingong has been experiencing heavy rains since this evening.

Throughout the day weather in Chittagong, Chittagong Hill Tracts and Khulna districts remained bad with light to heavy showers.

In Dacca the sky became murky in the afternoon and the situation was intensified by the gusty wind and rains.

The people, who were in constant touch with the Radio, took precautions and hurried back to their houses early.—APP.

According to the Meteorological Office, maritime ports of Chittagong, Cox's Bazar, Khulna and Chalna had been alerted to keep hoisted Great Danger Signal, while great danger preparedness was advised in seven of the 19 districts of the Province, including five coastal districts.

# EAST WING CYCLONE DEATH TOLL REPORTEDLY 2.5 LAKH

*Vast area lies in  
shambles*  
Stench of death  
everywhere

*Patuakhali, Hatiya worst hit*

From MAHBUBUL ALAM

DACCA, NOV 15: TWO AND A HALF LAKH PERSONS ARE FEARED, ACCORDING TO UNOFFICIAL ESTIMATES, TO HAVE PERISHED IN THE DEADLY DEALING CYCLONE WHICH RAGED UNBRIDLED OVER THE SOUTHERN AREAS OF EAST PAKISTAN FOR SEVERAL HOURS ON THURSDAY NIGHT LEAVING BEHIND A TRAIL OF DEATH AND DESTRUCTION UNPRECEDENTED IN LIVING MEMORY OF AN AREA WHERE HURRICANES ARE ALMOST AN ANNUAL AFFAIR.

A VAST AREA, COMPRISING MANY DISTRICTS, LIES IN SHAMBLES, WITH THE STENCH OF DEATH EVERYWHERE AS THOUSANDS OF DEAD HUMAN BEINGS AND CATTLE AWAIT DISPOSAL. COMMUNICATION WITH MOST OF THE DEVASTATED AREAS IS AT ITS BEST DIFFICULT.

It is impossible to assess the loss in terms of life and property just now as only a house-to-house survey could reveal how many are missing and how many have been counted dead.

The worst-affected areas are Hattya, Nemagail, Char Jabbur, Char Alexander of Soukhali District, Bhola Sub-Division of Barisal and coastal areas of Patuakhali. The over 20ft high wall of water washed away everything

Complex bodies have been found on the shore or floating in rivers. Thousands of bodies were given mass burials in different areas of Nuskhal District. It is difficult to keep track of the number as it keeps on swelling every hour.

A section of local newspapers have reported that several thousand more corpses—most of them in a state of decomposition being eaten by birds and beasts—are awaiting burial for want of cloth for shrouds. District authorities

in Nongkhong were yesterday frantically trying to find cloth as the stock in Nongkhong market has already exhausted. Transporters were rushed to adjoining districts and 100 sent to Daeng for cloth.

Reports from some of the worst-affected areas quoting eyewitness accounts say that these places have been reduced to shambles with no sign of life at places where the silence of grave prevails.

*The dead . . .*



A surviving father, right, searches among bodies of dead children on Bhola Island in an attempt to identify his son.—AP.

# ELECTION 1970

- Election to the 17 seats affected by the cyclone were postponed. Yahya proceeded to hold elections to other seats as scheduled earlier on 7 December 1970.
- Awami League went to the people with the six point programme as its election manifesto. Election was held throughout Pakistan on 7 December 1970.
- Much to the surprise of Yahya Khan, Awami League secured clear majority in the election of Pakistan National Assembly with 167 seats out 333 seats (72.57%) including 7 seats reserved for women. Bhutto's party secured 88 seats (42.2%). Awami League victory in the Provincial Assembly Election held on 17 December was also stunning, securing 298 seats including 10 women seats out of 310 seats (89% vote cast).



**Table 10.1: Results of the 1970 National Assembly Elections (East Pakistan)**

| Name of the Party      | Number of Candidates | Seats Won | % of Total Votes Polled |
|------------------------|----------------------|-----------|-------------------------|
| Awami League           | 162                  | 160       | 72.57                   |
| NAP (Moscow)           | 36                   | -         | 1.83                    |
| NAP (Peaking)          | 15                   | -         | 0.30                    |
| Islamic Parties        | 515                  | 1         | 17.85                   |
| Independent and others | 139                  | 1         | 7.72                    |
| Total                  | 867                  | 162       | 100                     |

Source: Talukder Maniruzzaman, *The Bangladesh Revolution and Its Aftermath*, (Dhaka, UPL 2003), p.73.

**Table 10.2: Results of the 1970 National Assembly Elections (West Pakistan)**

| Name of the Party               | Number of Candidates | Seats Won | % of Total Votes Polled |
|---------------------------------|----------------------|-----------|-------------------------|
| Pakistan People's Party (PPP)   | 119                  | 81        | 42.2                    |
| Muslim League (Convention)      | 158                  | 11        | 10.2                    |
| Muslim League (Quayyum)         | 69                   | 7         | 10.8                    |
| Muslim League (Council)         | 27                   | -         | 1.8                     |
| Pakistan Democratic Party (PDP) | 79                   | 4         | 6.5                     |
| Jamat-E-Islami                  | 147                  | 14        | 10.2                    |
| Other Islamic Parties           | 19                   | 6         |                         |
| NAP (Moscow)                    | 4                    | -         |                         |
| NAP (Peaking)                   | 9                    | -         | 18.5                    |
| Awami League                    | 223                  | 15        |                         |
| Independent and others          | 854                  | 138       | 100                     |
| Total                           |                      |           |                         |

Source: Talukder Maniruzzaman, *Bangladesh Revolution*, p.73.



# YAHYA CONVENES NATIONAL ASSEMBLY IN DHAKA

- On 13 February 1971 Yahya Khan convened National Assembly in Dhaka on 3 March 1971.
- But PPP leader Zulfikar Ali Bhutto's reaction to this announcement was unfavourable and a further step forward towards a crisis.
- He expressed inability of his party to attend the National Assembly session on 3 March in Dhaka in the absence of a compromise or adjustment on six points programme.
- On 16 February in Karachi, Bhutto stated "his party's decision not to attend the ensuing session is unshakable and irrevocable"
- In these circumstances, the regime engaged in conspiracy with Bhutto to thwart not only the election verdict but also to recourse to military action against Bengali.





# NATIONAL ASSEMBLY POSTPONED

- As part of the Larkana conspiracy, National Assembly was postponed on March 1 for an indefinite period before 2 days of the session which was scheduled to be held on 3 March.
- As soon as the postponement was declared, the people's fury in East Pakistan erupted like volcano. So intense and widespread was the reaction that the regime and West Pakistani politicians and even Awami League got awestruck. The slogan raised was 'Bir Begali astra dhara, bangladesh sadheen kara' (brave Bengali take up arms and liberate Bangladesh)
- In these extraordinary circumstances, the undisputed leader of the Bengalis, Bangabandhu Sheikh Mujibur Rahman called for Gandhian model of non-violent and non-cooperation movement. Starting from March 2, it continued until military crackdown on 25 March.





# HISTORIC 7 MARCH SPEECH

- Sheikh Mujibur Rahman started with the lines, "Today, I appeared before you with a heavy heart. You know everything and understand as well. We tried with our lives. But the painful matter is that today, in Dhaka, Chattogram, Khulna, Rajshahi and Rangpur, the streets are dyed red with the blood of our brethren. Today the people of Bengal want freedom, the people of Bengal want to survive, the people of Bengal want to have their rights. What wrong did we do?"
- He mentioned four conditions for joining the National Assembly on 25 March: the immediate lifting of martial law, the immediate withdrawal of all military personnel to their barracks, the immediate transfer of power to elected representatives of the people and a proper investigation for the loss of life during the conflict.
- He also gave several directives for a civil disobedience movement, instructing that:
  - 1) people should not pay taxes
  - 2) government servants should take orders only from him
  - 3) the secretariat, government and semi-government offices, and courts in East Pakistan should observe strikes, with necessary exemptions announced from time to time
  - 4) only local and inter-district telephone lines should function
  - 5) railways and ports could continue to function, but their workers were told to not co-operate if their activities would help the repression of East Pakistan.
- The speech lasted for about 19 minutes and concluded with, "The struggle this time, is a struggle for our liberty. The struggle this time, is a struggle for our independence. Joy Bangla!" It was a de facto declaration of Bangladesh's independence.





